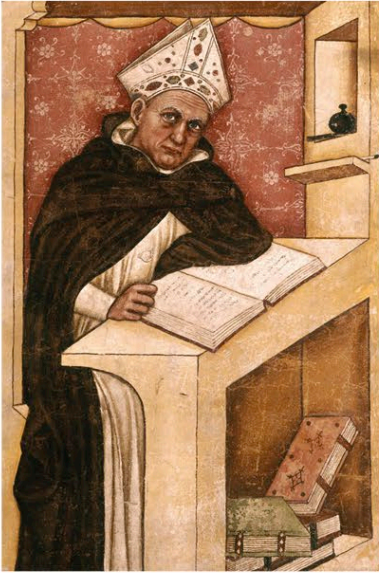




ALBERT THE GREAT OF COLOGNE (1193–1280)

Justifying astrology

Albertus Magnus (Albert the Great) was a leading scholar who promoted the idea that all humans have free will. He was also an expert on astronomy and music, and reputed to be an alchemist and magician, famous for his *Book on Minerals*, one of the first great texts on mineralogy. He was said to have discovered the Philosopher's Stone—the miraculous stone that could turn base metal into gold (see pp.148–151). Albertus believed that the use of astrology and the study of the magical powers of plants and stones were forms of natural science—far removed from the evil summoning of demons that characterized necromancy. Albertus Magnus was made the patron saint of natural sciences in the 20th century.

Arab texts

In the early medieval period there was no concept of magic as a subject of organized study. The arrival of Arabic texts on magic, in Latin translation, in the 12th century had a big impact on the Christian world. Scholars would often translate books on occult sciences such as astrology, alchemy, divination, and magic alongside works of more conventional disciplines such as mathematics. In this way, magic became an established part of the scholarly scene, like astronomy and geometry.

Translators were excited by those Arabic magic texts that provided an insight into the workings of the cosmos, and some developed their own theories. Spanish philosopher and linguist Dominicus Gundissalinus argued that magic was a natural science—a legitimate area of scientific inquiry, providing insights into mysteries, such as the apparently magical power of magnets.

This idea of magic as a natural science, alongside natural philosophy, gained a hold among some intellectuals. For them, magic effects, if observable, were real and natural, even if only understood and controlled by a few.

◀ Expressing divine marvels

Philosophy and the liberal arts are encircled in this illustration from an encyclopedia compiled by Abbess Herrad of Landsberg, Alsace, in the 12th century. Magicians, along with poets, are shown excluded from the circle, and subject to evil inspiration (the black birds on their shoulders). As the century progressed, scholars sought to raise the status of magic.

Some scholars specialized in particular areas of magic in nature. Writers of lapidaries (handbooks on the powers of stones), such as Albertus Magnus, argued that the magic of stones was a natural quality bestowed by God. The Peterborough lapidary of the 15th century was by far the longest and most comprehensive, listing the occult properties of 145 stones. Such notions inspired ordinary people to incorporate stones into objects such as talismans, rings, and knives, given magical powers—through rituals with inscriptions or spells—to guarantee wealth or protect from disease.

Work of the Devil

Toward the end of the medieval period, the philosophical and theological debate hardened. The clergy began to demonize astrologers and alchemists, and paint magic as a pact with the Devil. The Church became increasingly split by heretical movements and, in 1230, the Inquisition was set up to protect it from dissenting voices. Practitioners of magic, especially scholars, risked accusations of *sortilegium* (sorcery), and so became secretive in order to protect themselves—but their very secrecy aroused suspicion.

▼ Naturally magical

This 13th-century English manuscript, the *Liber Additamentorum* (“Book of Additions”) by Benedictine monk Matthew Paris, is illustrated with drawings of gems, rings, and cameos inset with precious stones, which people wore for their protective powers.

